The Ladders gets its name from the steps cut into the rock face on the west bank of the Lohit River as the Kibithu-Walong track negotiates this geographical barrier. Major N. B. Chand, who had placed his main position about a kilometre and a half to the rear, commanded 3/3 GR's Charlie Company. From the company command post, the track ran the distance, about a thousand feet above the river. Once it got to the rock face, the steps took the path onto a plateau. One of the platoons had its defences on the forward end of the plateau, while the other was dug into the vertical cliff itself. These bunkers were like caves on the rock face. Both Delta Company on Lachhman Ridge and Charlie Company were under the command of 4 Sikh, just as the Sikh company across the river on the east bank was under command of 3/3 GR.

The Chinese artillery could not hit the defences at The Ladders from any of their positions on the west bank. The forward platoon was dug in at the top end of the stairway, which allowed it to have an excellent field of fire that completely dominated any frontal approach. As the bunkers were chiselled into the hard rock The Ladders were almost impregnable. About two kilometres to the north was Ashi Hill, from where the Chinese had cut a path to Green and Yellow Pimple. Since 26 October, their guns had been trying to bracket both The Ladders and Mithun, but had not succeeded, while their own casualties were considerable.

The Chinese commander had realized fairly early that to capture Walong his only option was to create a path up the cliff from Ashi Hill on the western flank and get above the Indian positions. On the eastern flank, he would have to get enough troops across the Lohit to capture the Indian positions. Once he succeeded in doing that, he could bring into play his anti-tank 55 mm RCL guns. Delta Company of 4 Sikh was holding the High Plateau on the eastern flank under the command of Lieutenant Yog Raj Palta. So long as the Sikhs held their position, Chand was confident the Chinese could not dislodge his men on The Ladders.

Crossing the river and assaulting High Plateau was always going to be a risky proposition. The Chinese therefore launched a determined assault on The Ladders on the morning of 15 November. Instead of the usual ineffective artillery fire, the Chinese changed tactics and moved up 55 mm RCL guns that opened up in an attempt to soften the Gorkhas. As soon as the firing stopped, the Chinese infantry tried to rush the forward platoon, but the Gorkhas were ready with their deadly accurate .303s and LMGs in